

Mastering Focus Under Pressure

Attention, Concentration, and the Inner Game of Performance

How skilled performers prepare, regulate attention, and stay present when the stakes rise.

ATTENTION SYSTEM

Learn how selectivity, capacity, alertness, and shifting shape performance.

INNER GAME

See how Self 1 and Self 2 explain overthinking, trust, and automaticity.

MENTAL TOOLKIT

Build routines, imagery, cue words, breath control, and reset strategies.

Designed as a textbook-style chapter for clear teaching, practical coaching, and fast review.

Chapter thesis

Pressure usually does not erase skill. It reallocates attention. The better the athlete understands attention, interference, and self-regulation, the more often skill survives the moment.

Chapter roadmap

This chapter merges the scientific study of concentration with the applied “Inner Game” approach to performance. Together they explain how athletes can prepare attention before competition, protect it during performance, and recover it quickly when it drifts.

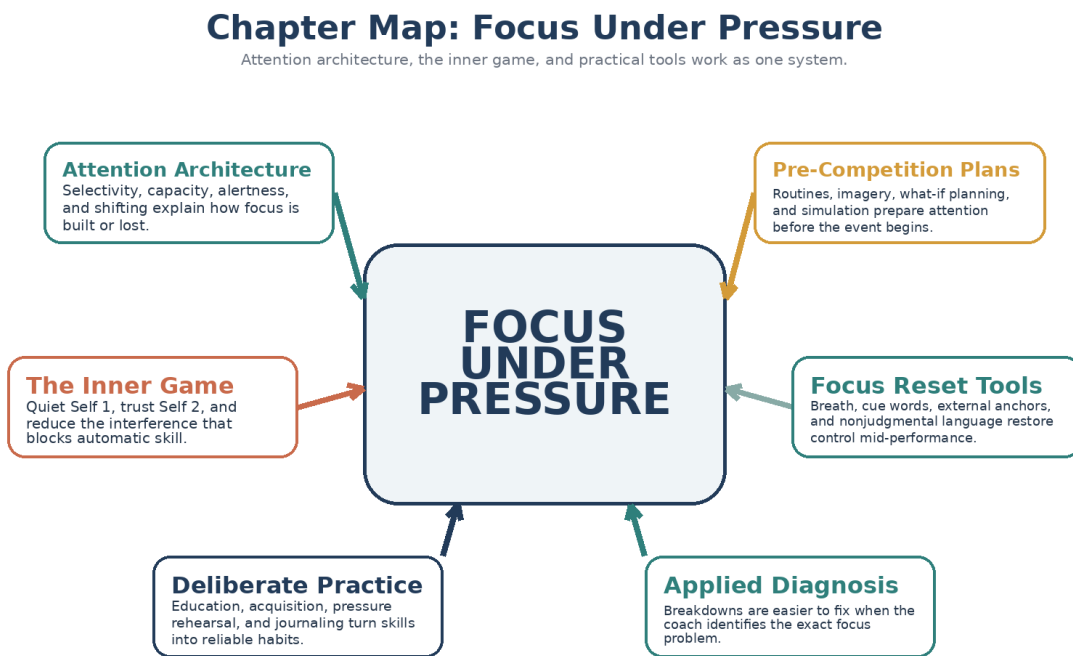


Figure 1. Focus under pressure is a system, not a single mindset trick.

INSIDE THIS CHAPTER

Why this chapter matters

Students often treat focus as if it were a vague personality trait: some people “have it” and others do not. That view is too simple. Concentration is a trainable performance skill. It can be diagnosed, rehearsed, disrupted, and rebuilt. Once coaches and performers understand the architecture of attention, breakdowns become easier to explain and easier to fix.

The deeper lesson is that pressure rarely invents a new athlete. It exposes the attentional habits the athlete already owns. A strong chapter on concentration therefore has to cover both the science of attention and the lived experience of performance under pressure.

Learning objectives

- Define concentration as selective, sustained, and shiftable attention rather than simple effortful focus.
- Explain the core attentional processes of selectivity, capacity, alertness, and attentional shifting.
- Use Nideffer's attentional quadrants to diagnose what kind of focus a task requires.
- Differentiate Gallwey's Self 1 and Self 2 and explain the performance equation: potential minus interference.
- Design pre-competition routines, what-if plans, imagery scripts, and simulation drills that protect focus.
- Build an in-performance focus plan using breath control, cue words, external anchors, and nonjudgmental resets.

Study lens

Read this chapter with a diagnostic mindset. Instead of asking only whether an athlete was “focused,” ask what they were focused on, whether that focus matched the task, and how quickly they could shift when the moment changed.

SECTION 1: FROM PRESSURE TO BREAKDOWN

1. Why focus fails under pressure

Pressure does not simply add emotion; it changes what the mind attends to. In practice, athletes can devote substantial attention to technique, correction, and repetition with relatively little consequence attached. In competition, the same attentional system must manage evaluation, uncertainty, time pressure, fatigue, crowd noise, opponents, and the meaning of the moment. That combination can pull attention away from task-relevant cues and toward self-conscious monitoring or distraction.

When performance drops under stress, the athlete often still possesses the skill. What changes is access to the skill. Attention begins replaying the last error, predicting the next mistake, overanalyzing body mechanics, or listening to an inner critic narrate the entire event. These processes reduce fluidity, increase muscle tension, and make automatic skills feel strangely effortful.

Four common enemies of focus

Athletes commonly drift into past mistakes, future consequences, analysis paralysis, or the running commentary of the inner critic. All four consume bandwidth that should belong to sensing, deciding, and executing.

SECTION 2: THE ARCHITECTURE OF ATTENTION

2. Concentration as a trainable control process

In sport psychology, concentration refers to more than simply “trying to focus.” It includes the ability to select the right cues, keep attention there long enough to act, remain aware of important changes or errors, and shift attention efficiently when the task demands something different. That last piece matters because almost no performance task requires one static kind of focus from start to finish.

The architecture of attention is often explained through four linked processes. Each process can support performance or break it down, depending on how well trained it is and how much pressure is present.

Process	What it does	Performance value	Breakdown when weak
Selectivity	Screens out irrelevant information.	Keeps the spotlight on the most useful cue.	Noise, thoughts, and irrelevant events steal the spotlight.
Capacity	Manages limited mental bandwidth.	Lets experts execute skills automatically and still read the game.	Athletes become overloaded by mechanics, strategy, and emotion at once.
Alertness	Links arousal to readiness and attentional width.	Sharpens readiness when arousal is appropriate.	Too little arousal creates drift; too much creates tunnel vision.
Shifting	Moves focus as the moment changes.	Allows scan -> plan -> regulate -> execute transitions.	Athletes get stuck overthinking or staring at the wrong cue.

Table 1. Attentional control is multi-part. A performer can be strong in one process and weak in another.

Capacity is especially important for understanding why experts and novices perform differently. Novices spend large amounts of bandwidth on how to move. Experts can let well-learned skills run automatically, which frees attention for anticipation, tactical reading, and environmental awareness. Under heavy pressure, even experts can be pulled backward into conscious control if their focus plan is weak.

3. Nideffer's attentional quadrants

Nideffer's model is useful because it names different kinds of concentration instead of treating focus as one single state. Broad-external attention scans the environment. Broad-internal attention analyzes and plans. Narrow-internal attention regulates the body and mind. Narrow-external attention locks onto the immediate execution cue. Elite performers do not stay in one quadrant; they shift deliberately as the moment changes.

Four Attentional Quadrants

High-level performers shift deliberately instead of trying to use one kind of focus for every moment.

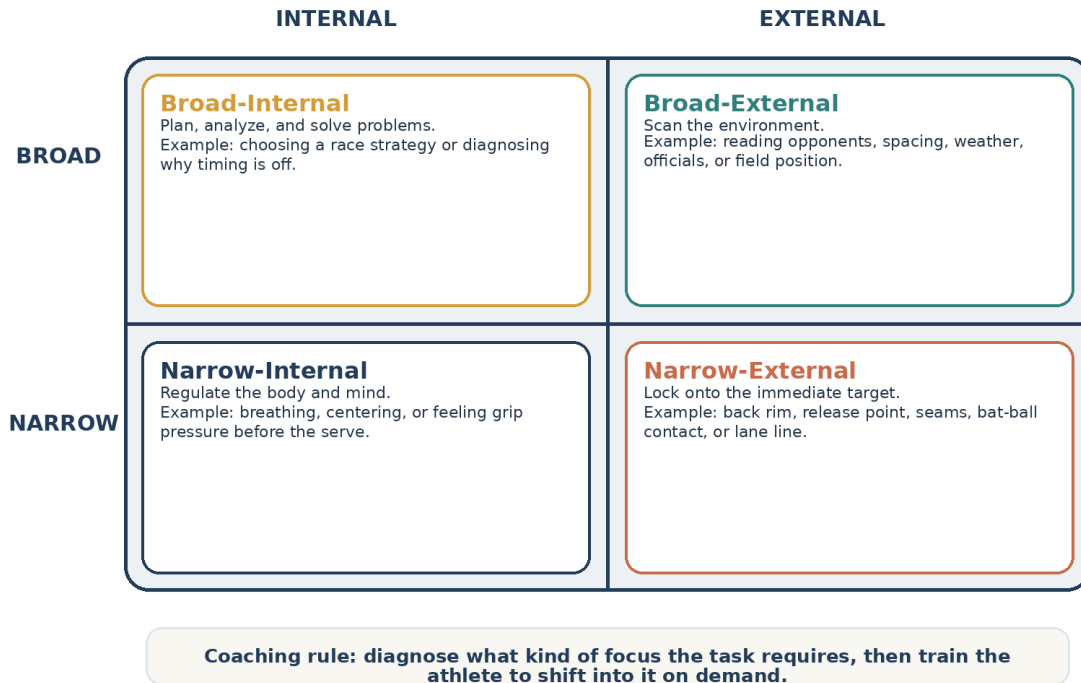


Figure 2. Different moments in performance demand different attentional widths and directions.

A free throw offers a simple example. Before the shot, the athlete may briefly use broad-external awareness to orient to the environment and game situation. Next comes a brief broad-internal decision about routine and tempo. Then narrow-internal attention organizes breath and body tone. Finally, narrow-external attention locks onto the target and release. Problems arise when athletes stay in the wrong quadrant too long, such as continuing to analyze mechanics while the shot is already unfolding.

Coaching implication

Do not diagnose every lapse as “lost concentration.” Ask what kind of focus the athlete needed, where their attention went instead, and whether arousal made the attentional field too broad or too narrow.

SECTION 4: THE INNER GAME

4. Self 1, Self 2, and the problem of interference

Gallwey's language of Self 1 and Self 2 gives an applied explanation for why attention can sabotage skilled movement. Self 1 is the verbal, analytical, judgmental part of the mind. It can be useful for setting goals, observing patterns, and choosing practice priorities. But during live execution it often overreaches by trying to micromanage

movement. Self 2 is the automatic, sensory, embodied system that actually performs the skill once it has been learned.

Gallwey's performance equation states that performance equals potential minus interference. Interference includes judgment, fear of outcome, overcontrol, and self-conscious correction. The athlete who says “Do not miss” or “Keep your elbow exactly here” while the skill is already unfolding is feeding Self 1 at the exact moment Self 2 needs room to work.

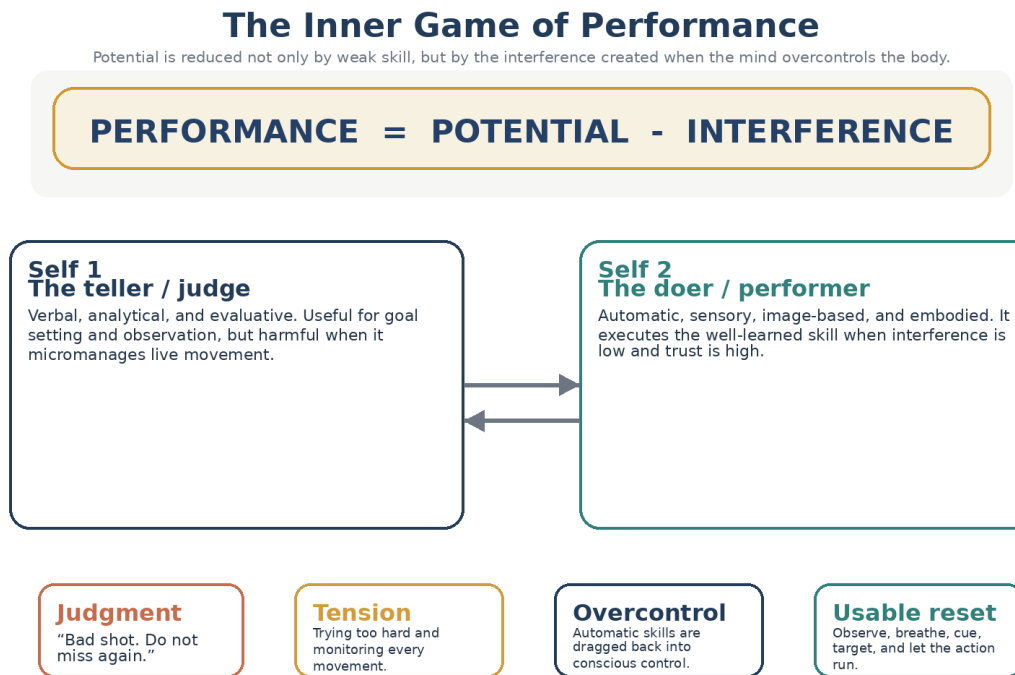


Figure 3. The Inner Game perspective frames pressure as an interference problem, not only a skill problem.

Feature	Self 1	Self 2
Core role	Sets goals, labels events, analyzes, and evaluates.	Executes the skill through automatic and sensory processes.
Strength	Useful for planning and observation.	Reliable, fast, and fluid once skill is learned.
Main risk	Overcoaching, judgment, and trying too hard.	Gets disrupted when Self 1 will not let it run.
Helpful language	Observe and choose the cue.	Feel, see, trust, and execute.

Table 2. The goal is not to eliminate analysis entirely, but to use it at the right time.

Nonjudgmental awareness is one of the most practical ways to reduce interference. Instead of “I am terrible under pressure,” the performer describes the event more accurately: “I was late on contact,” “I came off the target early,” or “I rushed the routine.” This style of observation preserves information while stripping away ego involvement. It keeps the athlete coachable in the moment.

Development lens

Treat skill development like growth, not a courtroom verdict. Errors are data about stage, timing, and need. The moment an athlete turns every mistake into an identity judgment, interference spikes and learning slows.

SECTION 5: PREPARATION BEFORE THE EVENT

5. Pre-competition plans that protect attention

A pre-competition plan is not superstition. It is an attentional transfer system. Its job is to move the athlete from everyday noise into performance-relevant readiness. The strongest plans blend stable elements - breath, body check, cue word, target image - with flexible responses to likely disruptions such as delays, bad calls, weather changes, hostile crowds, or a slow start.

Routines narrow attention. What-if planning reduces surprise. Simulation training makes pressure familiar. Imagery programs the body with sensory targets instead of endless verbal instructions. Some athletes also benefit from “programming by identity,” or briefly stepping into the role of the composed, decisive performer they want to become.

Pre-Competition Blueprint

The best plans transfer attention from life noise to task-relevant readiness before the event begins.

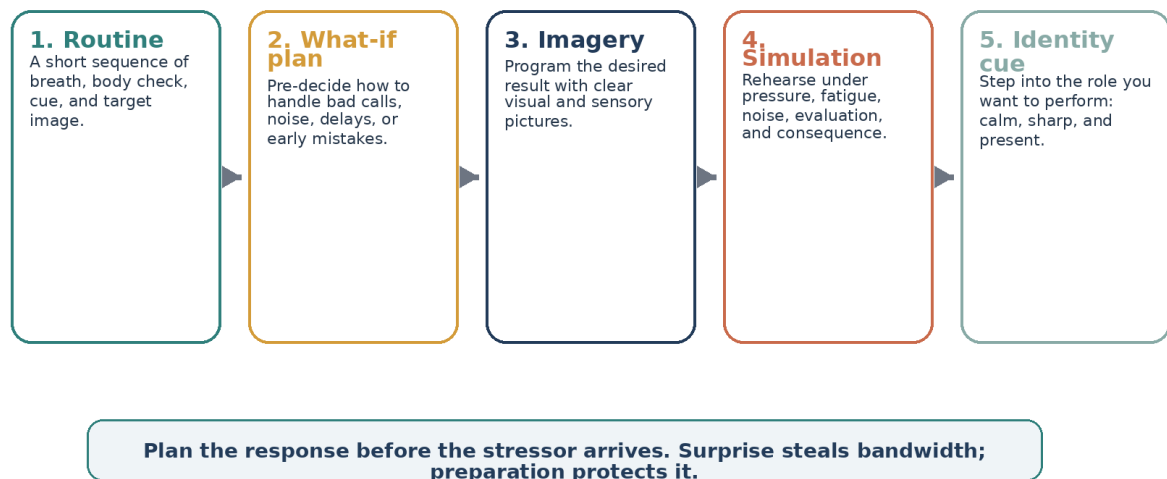


Figure 4. Preparation should not stop at hype. It should specify exactly how the athlete will think and respond.

Tool	Main purpose	Example	Common mistake
Routine	Transfers attention to controllables.	One breath, posture check, cue word, target image.	Too long, too rigid, or superstitious.
What-if plan	Prepares the response to likely distractions.	"If the call is bad, I breathe, reset, and play the next point."	Planning the problem but not the response.
Imagery	Programs the desired result or feeling.	See the arc, hear contact, feel rhythm before the rep.	Using vague or purely verbal imagery.
Simulation	Makes pressure familiar in practice.	Noise, consequence, fatigue, scoring, and evaluation drills.	Practicing only in safe, sterile conditions.
Identity cue	Links behavior to the role the athlete wants to embody.	"Compete like the calm version of me."	Trying to fake confidence without a routine underneath it.

Table 3. Good preparation reduces randomness. Weak preparation leaves attention vulnerable.

SECTION 6: FOCUS PLANS IN ACTION

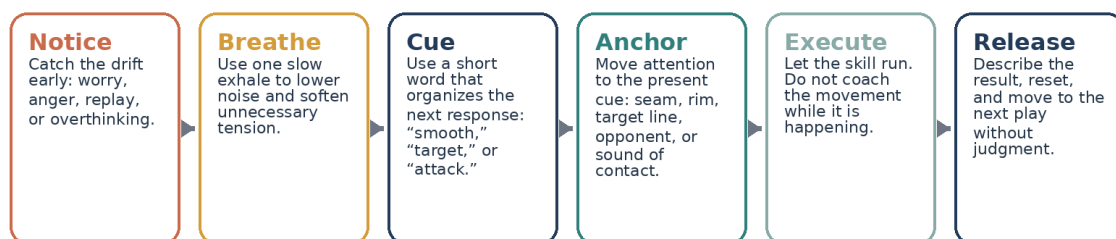
6. Regaining concentration during performance

A focus plan answers a brutally practical question: what will the athlete do the moment attention drifts? Many performers know that they "should refocus," but have no script for how. The most useful plans name a reset cue, a breath pattern, an attentional target, and a rule for how to respond after mistakes.

Cue words work because they compress a complex instruction into one usable trigger. Instructional cues are best when a specific technical reminder is needed. Motivational cues raise intensity when energy drops. External anchors such as the seams of the ball, the back rim, the lane line, or the sound of clean contact help keep the mind in the present and prevent analysis paralysis.

In-Performance Reset Sequence

A focus plan should tell the athlete exactly what to do the moment attention drifts.



The goal is not to "feel perfect." The goal is to recover quickly and return attention to what matters next.

Figure 5. Refocus is not a vague command. It is a rehearsed sequence.

Instructional vs. motivational cues

Instructional cues organize mechanics: “smooth,” “finish,” “eyes up.” Motivational cues organize effort: “drive,” “attack,” “explode.” Athletes get into trouble when they use technical cues in moments that actually require emotional settling, or emotional cues in moments that require precise target attention.

Breathing is especially valuable because it is both physiological and attentional. A slow exhale lowers noise, softens unnecessary tension, and gives the athlete a bridge back into the present. Gallwey's examples of watching the seams of the ball or listening for the sound of contact show the same logic: occupy attention with a simple, immediate cue so the critical mind has less room to interfere.

SECTION 7: TRAINING PROGRESSION

7. How focus becomes reliable

Psychological skills are most effective when trained in phases. Education gives the athlete a language for attention, interference, and arousal. Acquisition teaches the actual tools - cue words, centering, imagery, target focus, and nonjudgmental observation. Practice integration then takes those tools into increasingly competitive settings until they are available under stress rather than only in calm environments.

Useful drills include performance profiling, interference audits, seam-watching or target-gaze exercises, simulation training, and practice journals that record how the skill felt rather than only what the outcome was. Research on “quiet eye” behavior supports the same pattern: stable gaze on a task-relevant target immediately before action improves performance because it stabilizes attention at the right moment.

Symptom	Likely focus problem	Useful intervention
Replays mistakes	Past-oriented attention and judgment.	Short breath reset + describe the error objectively + next cue.
Thinks about outcome	Future-oriented distraction.	What-if planning + present-moment target cue.
Feels robotic	Overcontrol and narrow-internal overload.	External anchor + trust cue + simulated repetition.
Misses key cues	Attention too broad or directed wrong.	Re-define the target cue and rehearse scan-to-lock transitions.
Gets tight late in games	Arousal narrows attention too much.	Centering, exhale control, and pressure rehearsal.

Table 4. Diagnose the exact focus error before prescribing the tool.

Case lens: the anxious free-throw shooter

This athlete often becomes stuck in narrow-internal focus on mechanics and consequences. The fix is not more instructions. The fix is a short routine: breathe, soften, cue, eyes on target, shoot, release. Then the routine must be practiced under pressure until it becomes the default response.

REVIEW AND CONSOLIDATION

End-of-chapter summary

Concentration is a trainable control system built from selectivity, capacity, alertness, and shifting. Pressure does not merely test courage; it tests how well attention has been prepared. Nideffer's quadrants explain what kind of focus the moment requires, while Gallwey's Inner Game explains why overthinking and judgment interfere with automatic skill.

Pre-competition plans protect attention before stress arrives. Focus plans restore it when stress breaks through. The most effective performers do not chase a mystical state of perfect calm. They learn how to diagnose drift early, recover quickly, and return attention to the cue that matters now.

Key takeaway

Focus under pressure is not one skill. It is a coordinated system of preparation, attentional direction, arousal regulation, and recovery.

Multiple-choice review

1. Which statement best describes concentration in sport performance?
 - A. Trying harder than everyone else
 - B. Selecting, sustaining, noticing, and shifting attention to the right cues
 - C. Eliminating all emotion before competition
 - D. Thinking about mechanics on every repetition
2. In this chapter, attentional capacity refers to:
 - A. The amount of pain an athlete can tolerate
 - B. The speed at which arousal rises
 - C. The limited amount of information a performer can process at one time
 - D. The number of routines an athlete memorizes
3. Which example best fits broad-external attention?
 - A. Feeling shoulder tension before a serve
 - B. Scanning spacing, defenders, and options before making a pass
 - C. Repeating a cue word during a lift
 - D. Locking eyes on the back rim during a free throw
4. Narrow-internal attention is most useful when the athlete needs to:
 - A. Read the whole competitive environment
 - B. Regulate breath, body tone, or timing before execution
 - C. React to crowd noise
 - D. Evaluate the final result after competition
5. Gallwey's performance equation states that performance equals:
 - A. Confidence plus effort
 - B. Potential minus interference
 - C. Talent plus repetition
 - D. Preparation minus fatigue
6. Self 1 is best described as the:
 - A. Automatic, sensory performer
 - B. Verbal, analytical judge that labels and evaluates
 - C. Physiological arousal system
 - D. Support network around the athlete
7. Which response best reflects nonjudgmental thinking after a mistake?
 - A. "I always choke under pressure."
 - B. "That proves I'm not built for this."

- C. "I was late on contact; next rep eyes on the target."
 - D. "Don't miss again or you'll blow it."
8. The main job of a good preperformance routine is to:
- A. Guarantee perfect calm
 - B. Shift attention onto controllable, task-relevant cues
 - C. Build as much intensity as possible
 - D. Analyze technique in detail during execution
9. What-if planning improves focus because it:
- A. Removes the need for practice
 - B. Pre-decides how to respond to likely distractions or disruptions
 - C. Makes pressure disappear
 - D. Prevents all attentional narrowing
10. An instructional cue word differs from a motivational cue word because it:
- A. Refines movement or technique rather than raising effort level
 - B. Is only used in practice, never in competition
 - C. Always increases arousal more strongly
 - D. Replaces the need for an external target
11. Centering and external anchors help under pressure by:
- A. Pulling attention back to the present and reducing mental noise
 - B. Increasing self-criticism so technique stays sharp
 - C. Keeping attention on the last mistake
 - D. Expanding attention to every possible cue
12. An anxious free-throw shooter who overthinks in games would likely benefit most from:
- A. More outcome-focused self-talk
 - B. A short breath-cue-target routine practiced under pressure
 - C. Constant mechanical instructions during the shot
 - D. Avoiding all rehearsal before competition

ANSWER KEY

Answer key with brief explanations

1. B - Concentration is a control process: it selects relevant cues, sustains attention, notices change, and shifts when needed.
2. C - Attentional capacity is limited mental bandwidth, which is why pressure and distraction can overload performance.
3. B - Broad-external attention scans the environment for opponents, spacing, timing, and tactical information.
4. B - Narrow-internal attention is used for regulation, such as breath, body tone, tempo, or grip pressure before execution.
5. B - Gallwey's core idea is that performance is reduced when interference pulls the athlete away from automatic skill.
6. B - Self 1 is the analytical and judgmental voice; Self 2 is the embodied performer that executes the learned skill.
7. C - Nonjudgmental language describes what happened in usable terms and points attention to the next controllable cue.
8. B - A strong preperformance routine organizes attention around controllables like breath, body position, cue words, and target.
9. B - What-if planning protects attention by deciding in advance how to respond to bad calls, noise, slow starts, or other disruptions.
10. A - Instructional cue words guide a specific movement or technical emphasis, while motivational cues raise effort or intensity.
11. A - Centering and anchors reduce noise by returning awareness to the present instead of worry, judgment, or overcontrol.
12. B - The chapter recommends a brief repeatable routine that steadies breath, narrows the cue, and is rehearsed under pressure.

Glossary of essential terms

Term	Definition
Alertness	The readiness level of the performer and the way arousal changes attentional width.
Attentional capacity	The limited amount of information a performer can process at one time.
Attentional shift	A deliberate move from one type of focus to another as task demands change.
Automaticity	Execution that requires little conscious control because the skill has become well learned.
Broad-external focus	A wide scan of the environment used to assess opponents, space, timing, or tactical options.
Broad-internal focus	Internal analysis used for planning, reflection, or strategic problem solving.
Centering	A brief reset routine, usually built around slow breathing and body awareness, used to regain control.
Concentration	The ability to direct attention to relevant cues, sustain it, notice important changes, and shift when necessary.
Cue word	A short word or phrase used to trigger a desired movement, feeling, or effort level.
External anchor	A simple outside cue - such as the seams of a ball, a target, or a sound - that stabilizes attention.
Focus plan	A personalized strategy for maintaining or regaining concentration during performance.
Imagery	The use of sensory images to rehearse outcomes, feelings, or movement patterns.

Glossary part 1. Use the terms as active language for coaching and self-analysis.

GLOSSARY CONTINUED	
Term	Definition
Interference	Anything that subtracts from performance potential, such as judgment, fear, or overcontrol.
Narrow-external focus	A tight focus on the immediate target or execution cue outside the body.
Narrow-internal focus	A tight focus on body sensations, breathing, or internal regulation.
Nonjudgmental thinking	Observing events accurately without labeling them as proof of personal worth or failure.
Performance equation	Gallwey's idea that performance equals potential minus interference.
Preperformance routine	A repeatable sequence of task-relevant thoughts and actions used before a skill or event.
Quiet eye	A stable visual fixation on a task-relevant target immediately before movement execution.
Selectivity	The ability to screen out irrelevant stimuli and focus on the most useful cues.
Self 1	Gallwey's label for the analytical, verbal, judgmental "teller."
Self 2	Gallwey's label for the automatic, intuitive, sensory "doer."
Simulation training	Practice that reproduces competitive stressors such as noise, consequence, time pressure, or evaluation.
What-if planning	Pre-deciding how to respond to likely distractions or disruptions before competition begins.

Glossary part 2. Use the terms as active language for coaching and self-analysis.